

Chapter 97_1 - Impropriety

This feeling was quite wonderful. Even through layers of clothing, she could feel the softness and warmth of her cheek. Ning Fuyi raised her hand slightly, forcefully suppressing the restlessness in her heart.

One hand used her sleeve to shield her, while the other gently lifted her chin, allowing her eyes, which had dilated from fright, to directly see her lip movements.

"Where is it?" Ning Fuyi asked calmly, without a trace of panic. This made Su Mo's numb hands relax somewhat.

She swallowed and raised her hand to point toward the right side, to the stone bridge covered with moss and weeds.

"It's coming over," Su Mo gestured with extremely small movements, her body continuing to shrink, only turning her back to the stone bridge.

Su Mo's face was deathly pale, her gestures increasingly frantic. "It's in front of me again."

"It's eating its own hand."

"It's smiling at me. Its mouth is full of blood. It..."

If Su Mo could speak, her tone would definitely be tinged with tears by now. Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to let her be frightened any longer. The hand protecting her pressed her into her embrace, then spread her five fingers behind Su Mo's back. Crackling pink immortal energy exchanged between her slender fingertips, and the surrounding cold wind suddenly became lighter.

"What about now?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Su Mo was so panicked that she had no awareness of being tightly curled in the woman's embrace. She placed both hands on Ning Fuyi's shoulders and slowly looked in that direction.

"It stopped?" Su Mo raised her hand to gesture, her eyes full of surprise, and her fear also lessened somewhat.

"It seems to be afraid of something, yet very angry." Su Mo breathed out deeply, then instinctively looked at Ning Fuyi, doubts arising in her heart.

"Is it afraid of you?" Su Mo's willow brows slightly raised.

"Perhaps," Ning Fuyi answered ambiguously, then changed the subject. "This type of spiritual entity's power is truly insufficient. However, it hasn't been laid to rest properly, or perhaps has unresolved attachments, which is why it can wander in this world."

"The ghosts you usually see don't attack you because they are merely drifting fragments of broken souls. They pose no harm to ordinary people and are muddled without thoughts." Ning Fuyi explained patiently. "But this soul fragment is obviously different - stronger than those little ghosts, though its power still cannot affect people."

"So even if it follows you, it cannot touch you. It's just that you happen to fear such things, which is why you're troubled by it." Ning Fuyi's voice was like willow catkins floating through the air, stirring the heart.

While she spoke, the ghost had already stopped eating its hand. Instead, it hung half a sleeve, its bloody and mangled face still showing some expression, tilting its head and staring blankly at them, cowering and not daring to approach.

Although its appearance was still terrifying, the original horror changed flavor with Ning Fuyi's serious explanation. For a moment, Su Mo felt as if she were standing in a medicine shop, listening to her father describe a toad whose belly had turned white from being squeezed.

She nodded.

"Then why does it keep following me?" Su Mo asked.

"As a spiritual entity, no one else can see it except you. Therefore, I guess it follows you not to frighten you, but to seek help," Ning Fuyi said gently. "How about you ask it?"

The woman possessed a reassuring power. Su Mo didn't realize that she had come to trust her so completely, and turned her head to look at the ghost.

When one person and one ghost made eye contact, Su Mo still trembled, but the woman's hand hidden in her sleeve remained in front of her, as if creating a barrier for her protection.

This time Su Mo didn't dodge, but firmly stared into those rotting, stinking eyes.

After a long time, it suddenly moved. The cloth stained with black blood scabs dragged on the ground as it drifted soullessly toward the inner courtyard.

Seeing this, Su Mo hurriedly tugged at Ning Fuyi, her hands dancing gracefully before pointing her beautiful index finger at the place where the blood trail was dragging.

Ning Fuyi knew she had guessed correctly and signaled Su Mo to lead the way. Although Su Mo was afraid, she was inherently strong-willed. She straightened her neck and was about to walk toward the inner courtyard when suddenly a hand reached out from behind, tossing half a wide sleeve to her.

Who are you looking down on? Su Mo bit her lip, but when her eyes glanced toward the dark corridor bridge, she still took the half sleeve and clutched it in her hand.

Ning Fuyi could no longer suppress the corners of her mouth.

The two of them walked along the corridor. Today there wasn't much daylight to begin with, and with the overhead canopy blocking some more, the surroundings appeared even more dark and sinister.

Ning Fuyi couldn't see anything and could only follow Su Mo. The rain had started again at some point, pattering on the roof tiles. Their footsteps were muffled by the moisture - one walking timidly, the other strolling calmly.

Something was wrong. Ning Fuyi suddenly looked up because there were additional footsteps behind them at some point, sounding like someone about eight feet tall, with steps sometimes fast, sometimes slow.

Ning Fuyi pulled Su Mo to a stop, then stood still and looked back at the empty, water-stained stone pathway.

"Come out," she said, lowering her eyes to brush water droplets from her skirt. The wet hem brushed against her ankles, cold and cool.

After a long while, the person who had been following them finally climbed over from outside the corridor. The tall figure became cowering upon seeing Ning Fuyi, his ornate silk sash and jade ornaments weighed down by rain and clinging to his body, looking like a drenched brocade bird.

It was none other than the master of this residence - Qin Xiaoran.

"What are you sneakily following us for?" Ning Fuyi had already guessed it was him, so she wasn't surprised, but she didn't have any good attitude either.

Qin Xiaoran wiped the water droplets from his face with his hand and straightened his back to appear imposing: "Ridiculous! This is Young Master's territory. You trespassed without permission and I haven't even troubled you for it, yet you're questioning me instead?"

"Yesterday's matter was my fault for wrongly accusing you. I apologize," Ning Fuyi said, then changed the subject. "I see this residence of yours is quite old. It must have been uninhabited for a long time?"

Qin Xiaoran didn't know what she meant by this, but when the woman's phoenix eyes gazed at him, he always felt his hands and feet tighten, unconsciously answering: "This courtyard was passed down from our ancestors. It's my Qin family's old residence. It was quite prosperous in the past, but later when grandfather went to the capital to become an official, the whole family moved there."

After answering, he realized something was wrong and pulled out a dagger from his waist, pointing it at Ning Fuyi while stuttering: "You, what do you mean by asking this? Not only did you trespass into someone's residence, but now you want to seize someone's home too! I'm telling you, if you cause trouble, I'll report to the authorities and have you arrested!"

Seeing him point his blade at them, Su Mo instinctively stepped in front of Ning Fuyi. Her veil brushed past Ning Fuyi's neck like willow catkins, tickling.

Ning Fuyi's heart rippled like rainwater collecting, and she reached out to pull her sleeve, indicating it was fine.

"Even if the whole family moved, ancestral homes are places that enshrine the spirits of forebears. Ordinary people would regularly send someone to maintain them. But I see your ancestral home overrun with weeds, filled with cold winds, showing no trace of maintenance."

"There must be a reason for this," Ning Fuyi smiled. "I won't hide it from you - I once learned some ghost-suppressing techniques from a passing immortal master, which is why I can see the abnormalities in your residence and came following these abnormalities."

"Since you're so unwilling, we'll take our leave." With that, she pulled Su Mo to leave, but saw the man call out "Hey" several times, raising his hand to block their way, his expression already softening.

He frowned and thought for a moment, then carefully said: "You can really see that this residence has abnormalities? You're not lying to me?"

"Why would I lie to you? Even if you gave me this broken residence, I might not even look at it," Ning Fuyi crossed her arms and sneered.

Qin Xiaoran had met many wealthy young ladies in the county and occasionally interacted with noble ladies from famous families in the capital. Now seeing that although this woman's clothes were simple, her hands were slender and white, with red lips, fair skin, and extraordinary bearing, she seemed to have an inherent nobility. She really didn't look like a commoner.

Not to mention her swift and decisive fighting yesterday - perhaps she really had some connection with the legendary immortal sects. If she could truly help him solve this ghost trouble, when word reached his father's ears, his reputation might improve somewhat.

Thinking of this, his face immediately broke into a smile, shaking his sleeves: "Since the young lady said so early on, how could I be harsh with you? Please, please!"

Su Mo couldn't constantly watch their lip movements, so she only caught fragments of the conversation. Now seeing Ning Fuyi convince Qin Xiaoran to be so flattering with just a few words, she was puzzled.

"It's fine. He doesn't understand sign language. Let's continue," Ning Fuyi gestured to her.

They continued forward, with Qin Xiaoran following behind Su Mo like a lapdog, wanting to say something to her. But Ning Fuyi on the side had already pulled Su Mo aside, and the two immediately switched positions, leaving Qin Xiaoran grasping at air.

Su Mo stumbled to steady herself, looking up in confusion with furrowed brows at Ning Fuyi, who was looking up at the roof beams, touching her high nose bridge.

"Rude," Su Mo thought, clutching her sleeve and quickening her pace.

This residence was indeed large. After walking for another half incense stick's time¹, Su Mo finally stopped and secretly gestured to Ning Fuyi.

"It's gone."

Now they were in a small courtyard even more dilapidated than the outside. The stone bricks used for paving were already crisscrossed with cracks, and countless weeds sprouted from the accumulated dust of years. The earthy smell filled the moist wind.

Rusty and broken hoes and axes lay scattered on the ground, along with a pile of unfinished firewood that had rotted and turned black, sprouting grotesquely shaped mushrooms.

"How did we end up here? This is just a place for chopping wood and making charcoal. There shouldn't be anything here, right?" Qin Xiaoran was already covered in goosebumps, rubbing his arms as he spoke.

"Oh? If there's nothing here, why are you cowering?" Ning Fuyi seemed to always have an issue with him, speaking without mercy.

Qin Xiaoran wanted to retort but restrained himself, saying sullenly: "When I was young, I returned to town with my parents to visit relatives and stayed at the ancestral home for a while. I ran around playing and snuck from the front courtyard to this place. After that, I lost my memory. I only know the nursemaid who was watching me said I was found collapsed in a corner, and I had a high fever for three days after returning."

"Later, my father had someone use talismans to seal this courtyard. But now that years have passed, the elders have forgotten about it, and those original talismans have been blown away by the wind."

Su Mo watched his lips finish speaking, then turned to Ning Fuyi: "It should be here. Although I can't see that thing anymore, the smell is still there."

"A very heavy smell of blood." She placed her right index finger on the back of her left hand, making a motion of blood dripping.

Ning Fuyi nodded and signaled Su Mo to stay where she was. She wandered around the courtyard and finally stopped at a corner piled with baskets. Then she picked up a rake leaning against the wall and swept away all the debris.

As mud and water splashed, a heavy iron plate covered in rust appeared before their eyes. Rain drops pattered on the plate, washing away the dust and revealing rust stains that made one's scalp tingle.

"Come here." Ning Fuyi turned and beckoned to the two, indicating for Qin Xiaoran to lift the iron plate. Although Qin Xiaoran was extremely reluctant, he bent down and huffed and puffed to do it under Ning Fuyi's pressure.

Soon, a seemingly bottomless black hole saw daylight. The moment the covering was removed, overwhelming stench poured out from the hole. All three stepped back, quickly covering their noses and mouths.

"So stinky! If I had known, I would have brought my subordinates along, instead of having to face this filth myself now!" The pampered Qin Xiaoran covered his nose and mouth with his sleeve, cursing loudly.

"Shut up." Ning Fuyi said. She looked down into the hole and didn't sense any danger, so she took out a fire starter, lit it, and threw it in. Seeing that the fire starter didn't go out, she turned her head to signal Qin Xiaoran.

"Go down," she said.

"I think we should go out first and invite more Taoist priests or fortune tellers before coming back. If there's really something down there, you, a young woman, can't help me..." Qin Xiaoran smiled obsequiously while backing away.

Ning Fuyi said nothing more. She bent down to pick up a coil of hemp rope and approached him, frightening Qin Xiaoran into quickly raising his hands: "What are you planning to do?"

The young woman smiled at him: "Miss here doesn't like to leave the mountains often, and when I do, I don't like others getting in the way. Since you're unwilling to go down, fine - I'll just tie you up and have you wait here."

"I'll go down." Qin Xiaoran pointed at Ning Fuyi, changing his tune quickly. "I'll go down right now."

With that, he looked at the hole of unknown depth, clenched his fists in despair. He was already afraid of this place - if he really had to wait alone in the courtyard, it would be worse than staying by this woman's side, which seemed safer.

Besides, Miss Su Mo was still here. He couldn't appear too cowardly, lest it ruin Miss Su Mo's impression of him and make it even more of a loss.

Thinking this way, he felt his whole body fill with courage again. So he turned his back to Su Mo and shouted: "Miss Su Mo, this humble one is going down now. You should..."

However, before he could finish speaking, he felt his buttocks being heavily kicked. The rest of his words immediately turned into screams as he leaped into the entrance, and the screams abruptly stopped.

Su Mo was startled and immediately pulled back her hand, about to step forward to check, but Ning Fuyi raised her hand to stop her. Looking back, she saw the woman's expression seemed quite pleased.

"Don't worry, he won't die," Ning Fuyi slowly rolled up her sleeves. When her lotus-white arms were exposed, she lightly jumped down, landing steadily.

Qin Xiaoran was sweating profusely with fright, half-crouching in a damp corner wiping sweat, thinking to himself that this woman's heart was even more vicious than her appearance suggested.

Looking up, the vicious woman was spreading her arms toward the skylight above, saying gently: "Don't be afraid, just jump down."

What a strange thing! What exactly was this woman's relationship with Miss Su Mo? How was it that when it came to Miss Su Mo, not only did her tone become as gentle as water, but even her expression changed?

"She can't hear anyway. Why waste your effort?" Qin Xiaoran drew circles on the ground with his feet.

Su Mo looked at the entrance like a giant abyss, feeling very uneasy. But thinking of the torment of these years, she finally closed her eyes and leaped down.

Her skirt was caught up by the wind, sleeves and hair tangling in mid-air before being pulled down by her body. Just as she was about to scream, she felt her toes touch a soft palm. That palm quickly slid along her body as she fell, finally stopping at her waist, steadily embracing her mid-fall.

She hadn't had such contact with anyone for many years. The friction was so vivid it seemed carved into her heart. Her veil, already soaked with water, now heated up and stuck wetly and hotly to her face.

She moved uncomfortably and quickly pushed Ning Fuyi away, her white throat involuntarily swallowing.

Ning Fuyi's embrace still retained the feeling of holding that slender waist. She withdrew her hands into her sleeves, turned to pull the stunned Qin Xiaoran, and handed him the fire starter: "Let's go."

The ground was wet and muddy everywhere. The south had always been rainy, so this type of cellar was completely useless and had long been abandoned. As they walked deeper into the cellar, the stench became increasingly heavy.

Qin Xiaoran was several times overcome by the smell, rolling his eyes and constantly retching.

Ning Fuyi looked back at Su Mo, only to discover she had stopped halfway at some point, staring straight into the depths of the cellar. Her face was deathly pale, her skirt swaying with her body's trembling - her legs could give out at any moment.

Ning Fuyi quickly returned to her side, putting one arm around her shoulder. Fortunately, she didn't struggle but instead shrank beside Ning Fuyi like finding a lifeline, desperately gripping her arm.

Seeing her so frightened, Ning Fuyi's heart grew heavier with suppressed anger. So with her back to Qin Xiaoran, she said: "I have a method that can let me see what you see, but you might have to suffer a bit. Are you willing?"

Su Mo breathed rapidly and nodded repeatedly.

So Ning Fuyi didn't hesitate. She took out a small knife and lightly cut Su Mo's fingertip. The wound immediately began bleeding. Su Mo's hand flinched for a moment but didn't withdraw.

Ning Fuyi carefully took some blood, then walked to Qin Xiaoran's side and raised her hand to smear the blood on his eyelids. Just as Qin Xiaoran was about to question what she was doing, his pupils immediately dilated and he became motionless as if dead.

After a moment of silence, his heart-rending screams echoed through the cellar. Now he couldn't care about face anymore, rolling and crawling toward the entrance, but Ning Fuyi hooked his collar with her hand and forcibly dragged him back.

She applied the remaining blood to her own eyes. When she opened them again, everything in front of her seemed covered with a layer of scarlet gauze. Through this thin veil, she saw a completely rotted "person" standing expressionlessly in front of her, almost face to face.

Even Ning Fuyi closed her eyes slightly to show her fright.

"My dear mother, Heaven, King of Hell, Jade Emperor, Amitabha Buddha..." Qin Xiaoran was so scared he lost control of his bowels, his brocade robes stained with mud. For a moment, it was unclear whether it was water from the ground or if he had truly lost control.

Such a terrifying thing - Su Mo had actually been looking at it for so long. Murderous intent arose in Ning Fuyi's heart. She opened her eyes again, staring coldly at that "person" just the same.

Footnotes

1. **Half incense stick's time (半炷香的时辰)** - Traditional Chinese time measurement, approximately 15-30 minutes